Hubspark | Product Management Case Study 2027

Shiftwell: Smart Swap Rules Engine

Architecting an automated rules-based engine to halt portfolio churn

Candidate: Krishna Murthi

Working Prototype: Live Web Prototype

GitHub Repository: shiftwell-prototype (Repo)

FigJam Architecture: Bilateral Flow

Deliverable 1: Recommendation Memo to the CEO (Page 1 of 2)

TO:	Chief Executive Officer, Shiftwell	**DATE:**	October 18, 2026
FROM:	Krishna Murthi, Product Management	**SUBJECT:**	Q4 Engineering Build: What to Ship, Defer, and Why

1. Executive Summary & The Core Diagnosis

Our three largest enterprise accounts – FreshBowl (INR 84L ARR), CarePoint (INR 60L ARR), and UrbanMart (INR 110L ARR) – have submitted urgent, divergent feature requests. Sales recommends building all three. However, engineering capacity is strictly capped at **6 sprints** (2 engineers, 1 designer). The three requested custom builds total **6 sprints** (WhatsApp: 3, Overtime: 2, Certificates: 1), consuming 100% of capacity with zero contingency for QA, edge cases, or platform scale.

A rigorous diagnostic of customer interview transcripts and historical churn data uncovers the fundamental truth:

> **Root-Cause Finding:** Customers ask for communication channels (WhatsApp) and isolated rules, but their existential pain is **unbearable manager approval latency**. Every swap currently requires manual sign-off by a Location Manager.

Across our portfolio, **Swap Approval Speed (<24 hours) serves as a critical operational risk signal**:

- **Healthy Accounts** (UrbanMart, QuickKart, MedAxis): Average **70%** of swaps resolved in <24 hours.
- **At-Risk Accounts** (FreshBowl, FitZone, Brew & Co): Average only **34%** of swaps resolved in <24 hours.
- **Non-Budget Churned Accounts** (TandooriTown, GreenLeaf, PawsCare): Averaged **28.7%** (<35%).

While StyleHub (INR 30L ARR, 60% approval speed) churned due to macro budget cuts, the three remaining lost accounts all exhibited chronic approval latency under 35%. While sales recorded varied commercial reasons (price, spreadsheets, RotaPro), GreenLeaf's exit interview reveals how slow manual approvals create fatal product vulnerability: *"Honestly it wasn't WhatsApp. Our managers couldn't keep up with approvals, and RotaPro let swaps go through automatically if the person was trained."* WhatsApp merely moves an unmanageable queue from mobile app to chat; it does nothing to clear it.

2. Strategic Recommendation: Build the Rules-Based Auto-Approval Engine

Instead of three bespoke, disconnected features, I recommend engineering a single, configurable **Rules-Based Auto-Approval Engine** this quarter (**4 sprints total**). The engine evaluates incoming bilateral swap requests in real time against policy rules. When all active conditions pass, swaps resolve instantly without human friction.

Engine Rule Module	Functional Mechanism	Accounts Addressed	Sprint Cost
1. Role & Skill Match	Verifies swapper qualification, station certification, and role matrix.	FreshBowl + all restaurant/retail accounts	Core Engine
2. Overtime Threshold	Automatically escalates to Regional Manager if weekly hours exceed 48 hrs.	UrbanMart (INR 110L ARR) + labor compliance	Core Engine
3. Certificate Validity	Prevents scheduling or swaps involving staff whose mandatory credentials have expired.	CarePoint (INR 60L ARR) + clinical safety	1 Sprint
4. Auto-Approve on Pass	Instantly approves eligible swaps in <200ms; sends digest summary to managers.	Portfolio-wide (∼75% swaps automated)	Core Engine

Sprint Budget Allocation: Core Rules Engine: **3 sprints** | Clinical Certificate Module: **1 sprint** | Buffer & Hardening: **2 sprints**. Total: **6 sprints**.

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3. Strategic & Economic Justification

A. Resolves Primary Churn Drivers across INR 1.84 Cr of At-Risk ARR: FreshBowl (INR 84L, renewal Jan 2027), CarePoint (INR 60L, Dec 2026), FitZone (INR 22L, Oct 2026), and Brew & Co (INR 18L, Nov 2026) all suffer from manager scheduling bottlenecks (averaging 5.5–7.0 hrs/week). By auto-resolving ∼75% of swaps instantly, manager administrative load drops by ∼65%, aiming to reduce shift dropouts and protect INR 1.84 Cr in imminent renewals.

B. Neutralizes Competitor Threat (RotaPro): Sales fears RotaPro's WhatsApp feature. However, RotaPro won GreenLeaf because of *automatic approvals for qualified staff*. By shipping our Rules Engine, we neutralize RotaPro's operational advantage without incurring WhatsApp API messaging costs (INR 0.35/message across 10,160 monthly swaps = INR 85,000–INR 1,28,000/year in variable vendor costs avoided).

C. A Scalable Platform vs. Fragile Tech Debt: Building custom one-offs for UrbanMart and CarePoint creates maintenance liabilities. A rules engine is a reusable architecture: any enterprise customer can configure customized rules (e.g., rest periods, union seniority, minor labor laws) in future quarters.

D. Built-in 2-Sprint Safety Buffer: Building all three custom features would consume the full six-sprint capacity, leaving no contingency for unplanned work and increasing delivery and quality-assurance risk. Our plan consumes 4 sprints, preserving 2 full sprints for integration testing, edge cases, and pilot rollouts.

4. What We Will NOT Build This Quarter (and Why)

> **Deferred Initiative:** WhatsApp Swap Request & Approval Integration (3 Sprints).

Rationale: WhatsApp is a delivery channel, not a decision engine. At FreshBowl, store managers receive 25–30 swap requests every night. Sending 30 WhatsApp notifications per night to an overworked manager still results in delays, ignored messages, and burnout. By targeting auto-approval for roughly 75% of routine swaps, managers would handle approximately 25% of requests (roughly 6–8 exceptions on peak nights), with the exact operational reduction to be validated during our upcoming store pilot. We will re-evaluate WhatsApp in Q1 2027 specifically for *manager escalation alerts*, where it delivers genuine high-leverage utility.

5. Account-by-Account Stakeholder Communication Plan

- **FreshBowl (INR 84L ARR | Restaurants | Jan 2027 Renewal):** *"We investigated your frontline feedback. WhatsApp still leaves store managers with dozens of manual approvals. Instead, our Q4 engineering commitment is instant Auto-Approval for trained station staff. By targeting automation of roughly 75% of routine requests, we project saving managers ∼4.2 hours weekly (a ∼65% reduction from their current 6.5 hrs/week), aiming to reduce shift dropouts and speed up coverage during peak dinner rushes."*
- **CarePoint Clinics (INR 60L ARR | Healthcare | Dec 2026 Renewal):** *"We are addressing your regulatory audit exposure directly. We are committing Q4 engineering capacity to ship an integrated Certificate Expiry Enforcement Module that hard-blocks staff with expired BLS or Council credentials from scheduling or swapping, replacing manual spreadsheet tracking with automated system guardrails."*
- **UrbanMart (INR 110L ARR | Retail | Aug 2027 Renewal):** *"We are building the overtime governance controls you requested. Our Q4 Rules Engine build will introduce a configurable 48-hour weekly cap that automatically routes breaching swaps to Regional Managers for 1-click authorization."*

6. Decision Summary

Build the **Rules-Based Auto-Approval Engine**. It aims to protect INR 1.84 Cr in at-risk renewal ARR, addresses the primary operational driver of customer churn, delivers UrbanMart and CarePoint's explicit requirements, counters RotaPro's competitive moat, and leaves a 2-sprint buffer for rigorous quality assurance and rollout.

Deliverable 2: Reply to the Sales Head

Subject: Re: UrbanMart, FreshBowl, and Q4 priorities
Hi,
I hear you on the urgency – UrbanMart and FreshBowl are our two largest accounts, and losing GreenLeaf to RotaPro stings. But the churn data reveals that building WhatsApp and a custom overtime rule will not save these renewals.
Excluding StyleHub's budget cuts, all three lost accounts had approval speeds under 35%. While reasons like price were cited, GreenLeaf's exit interview revealed how manual friction creates vulnerability: RotaPro won because it auto-approved qualified staff swaps. RotaPro's real differentiator isn't WhatsApp – it's auto-approval.
Instead of building two disconnected features that consume all 6 sprints with zero contingency, I propose building a **Rules-Based Auto-Approval Engine** in ∼4 sprints:
1. **Auto-approves** qualified staff swaps instantly (solves FreshBowl's bottleneck far better than WhatsApp).
2. **Enforces overtime limits** with regional escalations (delivers UrbanMart's requirement).
3. **Blocks expired certificates** (secures CarePoint's INR 60L December renewal).

We protect all three accounts, address the root cause of portfolio churn, and preserve 2 sprints buffer. WhatsApp merely moves the queue to another screen; we are targeting auto-approval for up to 75% of eligible routine swaps, subject to pilot validation. Let's review the numbers together today.
Best Reagrds, Krishnamurthi

Word Count: 190 words (Strict Limit: 200 words)

Deliverable 3: Assumptions List (Where Data Was Missing)

In compliance with the case brief, all assumptions formulated where data was unstated are categorized below:

A. Engineering Sizing & Technical Architecture Assumptions

- **Sprint Velocity & Capacity:** Engineering capacity is fixed at 6 sprints for Q4 (2 engineers, 1 designer). I assumed full developer availability without unexpected sick leave or unplanned infrastructure incidents.
- **Core Rules Engine Scope (∼3 sprints):** Engineering notes quote 2 sprints for UrbanMart's specific overtime approval and 1 sprint for CarePoint's certificate field. I assumed standardizing these into a generalized, rule-evaluating engine takes 3 sprints, since the core pipeline logic (rule evaluation hook, status updates, notification dispatch) is built once and shared.
- **Absence of Existing Rule Infrastructure:** As confirmed by engineering ("every swap goes to Location Manager... there are no rules; this is hard-coded"), I assumed zero legacy rule infrastructure exists. The engine must intercept swap requests before they hit the database approval queue.
- **Mobile App Decoupling:** I assumed the mobile app only needs to display a new `Auto-Approved` status badge for swaps; no complex client-side architecture rewrites are required for frontline staff.

B. Customer Behavior & Churn Dynamics Assumptions

- **Auto-Approval Rate (∼75%):** FreshBowl's store manager states: *"I approve almost all of them without thinking. I only check if they're trained for the station and won't go into overtime."* Based on this, I assumed that 75%–80% of routine shift swaps satisfy role and overtime rules and can safely bypass manual review.
- **CarePoint Renewal Risk is Regulatory, Not Dissatisfaction:** CarePoint boasts a healthy 71% approval speed and low scheduling hours (4.0 hrs/week). Their "At Risk" status is entirely triggered by audit exposure (two shifts covered by nurses with expired BLS certificates). Solving credential blocking directly addresses CarePoint's stated churn vulnerability ahead of their INR 60L renewal.
- **UrbanMart Churn Imminence is Low:** UrbanMart's renewal is in August 2027 (10 months away), staff volume is healthy (5,200 staff), and swap approval speed is 64%. The VP HR's statement that they would "look at options" is standard enterprise negotiation posturing rather than imminent churn. Supplying overtime rules in Q4 satisfies their demand with 10 months of retention buffer.
- **FitZone and Brew & Co Root Cause:** Both accounts exhibit acute approval bottlenecks (35% and 29% <24h) and high manager workload (5.5 and 7.0 hrs/wk). I assumed their churn risk stems directly from the same manual approval gridlock affecting FreshBowl.

C. Financial Modeling & Unit Economics Assumptions

- **Manager Time Savings (∼65%):** Because ∼75% of monthly swap requests (portfolio total: 10,160 swaps/mo across 8 active accounts) will be resolved instantaneously without manager intervention, I assumed manager scheduling hours will decrease proportionally from an average of 4.75 hrs/week to ∼1.7 hrs/week (∼4.2 hrs/wk saved for FreshBowl based on a 65% reduction from 6.5 hrs/wk).
- **WhatsApp Cost Avoidance:** Engineering notes cite WhatsApp Business API messaging costs of INR 0.35/message. Across 10,160 swaps/month portfolio-wide (each requiring 2–3 template pings for request, approval, and confirmation), full adoption would incur INR 85,000–INR 1,28,000 annually in variable vendor costs (INR 24,000–INR 36,000/yr for FreshBowl alone). Auto-approval avoids this recurring cost.

Deliverable 4: Build Note

What the Prototype Does:
An interactive web application modeling Shiftwell's Rules-Based Auto-Approval Engine across four modules: (1) **Rules Configurator**: Live toggles and parameter tuning for Role Matching, Overtime Thresholds (48h), Certificate Validity, and Auto-Approval; (2) **Swap Simulator**: 5 dynamic scenarios (FreshBowl auto-approval, CarePoint BLS expired block, UrbanMart overtime escalation) demonstrating real-time step-by-step pipeline evaluation; (3) **Account Dashboard**: Visualizes all 8 accounts, churn correlation, and swap distributions; (4) **Impact Matrix**: Before/after operational metrics and sprint allocation.
How Built & AI Tools Used:
Engineered with semantic HTML5, Stripe/Linear-inspired high-contrast executive CSS design tokens, and vanilla JavaScript. Deployed on Netlify edge CDN. I used Antigravity IDE (Claude) to identify the approval-to-churn correlation, stress-test architectural tradeoffs, and scaffold interactive simulation logic. All figures match the case data pack.
Production Engineering Requirements:

- Configurable rule evaluation service with tenant-level policy overrides.
- Event-driven asynchronous worker queue for swap validation.
- Relational schema extensions for staff credential expiry and weekly hours calculation.
- Multi-tier manager escalation webhooks and immutable compliance audit logs.

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Deliverable 5: Working Prototype & Architecture Board Links

- **Live Deployed Web Application:** https://6ad4fc1fce522192bad9bf17–elaborate-parfait-1cc881.netlify.app/
- **FigJam Architecture & Policy Flow Board:** figma.com/board/OJXSOr8Sc4iL8QuREGRVgK/Bilateral-Swap-Policy-Engine-Flow (Node 9:69)
- **GitHub Source Code Repository:** github.com/krishnamurthi-ramesh/shiftwell-prototype

AI Usage Disclosure (Optional AI Chat Link)

- **Claude 4.5 & 4.7 Sonnet :** Assisted with prototype development, quantitative modeling, and exploring architectural trade-offs.
- **ChatGPT:** Assisted with reviewing the recommendation document, checking numerical consistency, identifying unsupported claims.
- **Audit & Prompt Documentation:** Prompt transcripts, development logs, and commit history are documented in docs/AI_USAGE_AND_PROMPTS.md on GitHub.

Appendix: Active Portfolio Data Pack & Churn Correlation Matrix

Account Name	Segment	Locs	ARR	Renewal	Approval <24h	Mgr Hrs	Account Health
UrbanMart	Retail	200	INR 110L	Aug 2027	64%	3.5h	**Healthy**
FreshBowl	Restaurants	120	INR 84L	Jan 2027	38%	6.5h	**At Risk (Gridlock)**
CarePoint Clinics	Clinics	40	INR 60L	Dec 2026	71%	4.0h	**At Risk (Audit Risk)**
QuickKart	Retail	90	INR 48L	Jun 2027	67%	3.0h	**Healthy**
Spice Route	Restaurants	60	INR 36L	Mar 2027	41%	6.0h	**Watchlist**
MedAxis Labs	Diagnostics	25	INR 30L	Feb 2027	80%	2.5h	**Healthy**
FitZone	Gyms	50	INR 22L	Oct 2026	35%	5.5h	**At Risk (Gridlock)**
Brew & Co	Cafes	35	INR 18L	Nov 2026	29%	7.0h	**At Risk (Gridlock)**
Total Active (8)	–	**620**	**INR 408L**	–	**Avg 53%**	**Avg 4.75h**	**INR 184L At Risk**

Historical Churned Accounts (Past 12M): Total INR 80L lost across 4 accounts. StyleHub (INR 30L, 60% approval) churned due to corporate budget cuts. The three non-budget losses—TandooriTown (INR 25L, 22%, price), GreenLeaf (INR 16L, 31%, RotaPro auto-approval), and PawsCare (INR 9L, 33%, spreadsheets)—averaged 28.7% approval speed, indicating that slow approvals serve as an important operational risk signal. Total active portfolio swap volume: **10,160 swaps/month**.